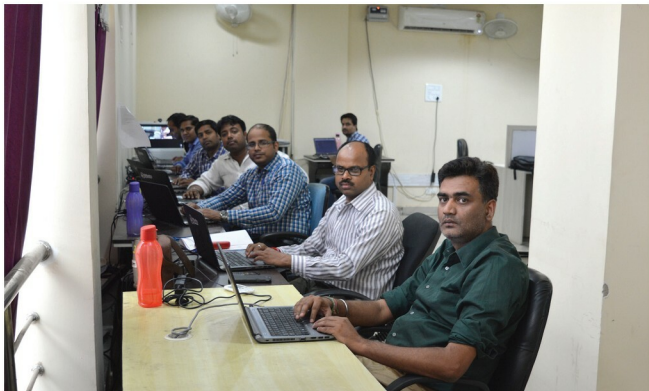


The Future of Indian E-governance Begins with OpenForge

In March this year, the government of India launched openforge.gov.in as an official platform to promote the 'open, share and collaborate' philosophy among its various departments. With a GitHub-like model, hosted within the country, the new platform is aimed at preserving and reusing the software assets in e-governance applications in the country.



The team that developed OpenForge

Collaboration and sharing are the two ancient practices among Indians. But when it comes to opening up the source code of government applications, you will rarely find state departments evincing much interest. A large number of multinational corporations, on the other hand, actively support community efforts today and participate in significant open source developments to attain technical superiority. This is why the government has now launched OpenForge.

"The objective of OpenForge is to promote the reuse of existing applications," explains Radha Chauhan, president and CEO, National e-Governance Division (NeGD). "Open source code will help in developing successful, scalable, high-quality e-governance applications in a collaborative manner. It will also encourage creativity in the application development process by encouraging collaborative development between government departments and agencies as well as private organisations, developers and citizens," she says.

The Ministry of Electronics and IT (MeitY) assigned the OpenForge project to the NeGD team that is responsible for having introduced the nation's digital locker system, DigiLocker, last year. Not only has the OpenForge platform been designed to support open source, but it also happens to be an open source project on its own.

Open source technologies: Behind the scenes

The NeGD team has used the open source collaboration platform Tuleap to build the repository solution. Under the hood, there is the LAMP (Linux, Apache, MySQL and PHP) stack.

"To jumpstart the process, we wanted to select an existing open source application rather than build one from scratch. We evaluated various applications on multiple parameters," says Amit Savant, technical product manager, NeGD.

There were two main challenges for the NeGD team in developing OpenForge as a successful open source